

GDPR Access Request - GitHub

As you may have guessed from the title, I chose to use [GitHub](#) as my provider of choice, seeing as it's a platform I use daily for both open source and professional work. No doubt similar to many others, ever since GitHub's acquisition by Microsoft in 2018 [\[1\]](#), I've had lingering questions about user privacy and how my data is being used, especially considering I heavily rely on GitHub for both hobby projects and to advance my career, inadvertently placing a lot of trust I would rather avoid in a large mega corporation such as Microsoft.

Recent perception of GitHub

Looking further into how my data is used by GitHub in particular and especially how it is passed to Microsoft feels particularly relevant currently seeing as the Zig Software Foundation (responsible for the programming language of the same name) have decided that now is the time to migrate hosting of their central source code repositories over to Codeberg [\[2\]](#), for a variety of reasons, including:

- A \$200,000 contract with ICE [\[3\]](#)
- Extreme bit-rot typical of a Microsoft product massively degrading usability for the end user [\[4\]](#)
- Pushing of artificial intelligence onto it's users [\[5\]](#)

This, of course prompted a large wave of similar re-evaluations of GitHub reliance across the open source community at large, especially since GitHub logins are frequently used as an OIDC provider [\[6\]](#), by association allowing Microsoft to track data given to them about the services logged in to in this manner.

Taking all of this into account, I felt now would be an opportune time to investigate just what data GitHub may have on me, which I'm sure is no doubt comprehensive considering my reliance on it as a product/service.

Publicly available data

When you start looking into how your data should be requested from GitHub [\[7\]](#), the first thing they send you to is your public available profile page, which in my case looks like this:

The screenshot shows the GitHub profile page for Luke Bailey (username: baileylu121). The profile includes a bio, location (Dublin, Ireland), and a list of pinned repositories. The contribution graph shows activity for 2025 and 2024. The recent contribution activity section lists several actions, including creating commits, repositories, and pull requests.

Profile Information:

- Name: Luke Bailey
- Username: baileylu121
- Location: Dublin, Ireland
- Followers: 9
- Following: 11

Pinned Repositories:

- nix-community/bun2nix** (Public): Generate a nix expression to build bun packages - similar to node2nix or yarn2nix [maintainer: @baileylu121]
- nixos-configuration** (Public): The full configuration for my nix system and home-managed modules.
- next-gear-motors** (Public): Web app for NextGear Motors garage - shop for vehicles, make reservations and more
- invariant** (Public): Invariant

Contribution Graph:

2,775 contributions in the last year

Contribution Activity:

- Created 179 commits in 9 repositories
- Created 2 repositories
 - baileylu121/invariant
 - baileylu121/infra
- Created a pull request in NixOS/nixpkgs that received 9 comments

lib.literalExpression: tag generated code blocks with `lib.literalCode`, add usage example and describe function arg; `lib.literalCode`: init

This is, of course, a page I am well aware of, having shared most of that data with the goal of being open and tying my identity to my open source work, and already reveals a lot of the data that GitHub has about me, including things like:

- The company I work for along with other organisations I'm a part of
- Precise activity day to day (presented in the green graph above)
- My name and approximate location

Exporting my account

As described on their page for requesting an archive of the account data [\[7-1\]](#), you may request a copy of all data GitHub has about you directly from your account settings page, which looks like:

Export account data

Export all repositories and profile metadata for **@baileylu121**. Exports will be available for 7 days.

Recent exports		New export	
19 minutes ago	1.44 GB	Delete	Resend email with link
31 minutes ago	1.44 GB	Delete	Resend email with link

In order to be GDPR compliant you may also send an email to dpo@github.com in order to request this same data, however in my case the content of this email [\[8\]](#) simply directed that I access the data in the very same manner, indicating that downloading this archive is likely a complete aggregation of the data GitHub is required to share about a user and that no alternative avenues exist in order to gain access to a more detailed/more complete repository of information about a user.

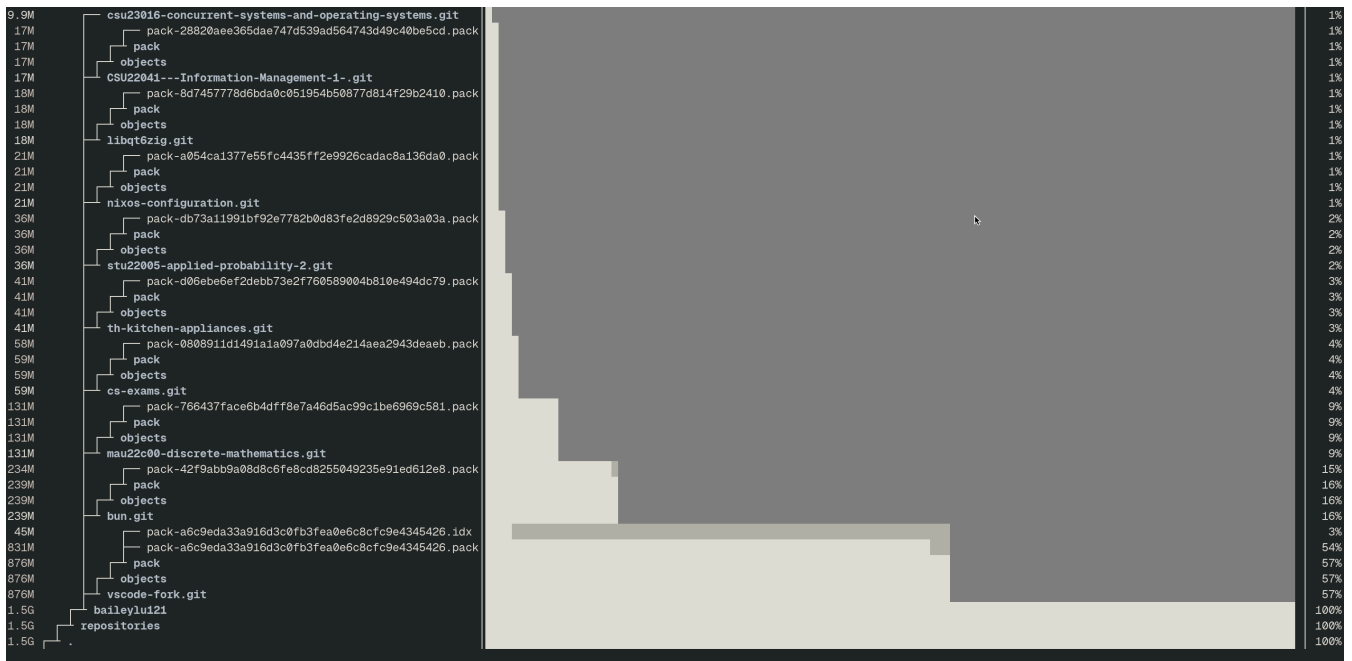
What's inside

Downloading the account data returned me a [1.4GB](#) tarball [\[9\]](#) containing all of the information GitHub shares about me.

```
~/Downloads
> ls
0936a684-dcf3-11f0-8c3f-8502d92a920a.tar.gz

~/Downloads
> tar -xvf 0936a684-dcf3-11f0-8c3f-8502d92a920a.tar.gz
./
./pull_requests_000001.json
./releases/
./releases/379aa4f2-fcc7-4f32-9c7e-cc6879ed71ec/
```

After extracting the tarball I had a poke around to see what was inside. The first immediately noticeable thing I saw was that the source code for every single one of the repositories under my individual user's organization was included with the download, which was the clear majority of the download size:



This is relatively unimportant from a privacy standpoint, so moving on the next most interesting thing was this `users_000001.json` file:

```
"website": null,
"location": "Dublin, Ireland",
"emails": [
  {
    "address": "baileylu@tcd.ie",
    "primary": true,
    "verified": true
  },
  {
    "address": "156000062+baileylu121@users.noreply.github.com",
    "primary": false,
    "verified": true
  },
  {
    "address": "bailey@fleek.xyz",
    "primary": false,
    "verified": true
  }
],
"social_accounts": [],
"billing_plan": {
  "name": "pro",
  "space": 976562499,
  "private_repos": 9999
},
"created_at": "2024-01-08T16:44:40Z"
},
{
  "type": "user",
  "url": "https://github.com/ayushdad22",
  "avatar_url": "https://avatars.githubusercontent.com/u/156011784?v=4",
  "login": "ayushdad22",
  "name": null,
  "bio": null,
  "company": null,
  "website": null,
  "location": null,
  "emails": [
    {
      "address": "156011784+ayushdad22@users.noreply.github.com",
      "primary": true,
      "verified": true
    }
  ],
  "social_accounts": [],
  "billing_plan": null,
  "created_at": "2024-01-08T18:41:42Z"
},
}
```

Which contained both my own user data and all public data about users I had frequently interacted with, which while it was interesting to read gave me no revelations about privacy. Similarly to this one were `pull_requests_00000<x>.json` files, which contain between them an entire list of every pull request I've ever submitted to the platform including both public and private repositories, `issues_00000<x>.json` which worked similarly for issues and a couple other less notable similar files.

Notable absent was any form of information pertaining to OIDC logins to external services that use GitHub as a provider, of which I have lost count of how many there should be. For example, one of these services which I use is Garnix [10], who provide build resources I use frequently for building and testing my projects in an isolated environment and whom exclusively exist as an integration with GitHub, however, when I run a string search for "garnix" in the tarball archive I downloaded from GitHub, there is nothing related to logging in to or using Garnix:

```
> rg garnix
issue_comments_000001.json
37:  "body": "isFormatted fails as\r\n\r\n""console\r\n(nix-formatted-0.1.0- Error: failed to finalise formatting: formatting failures detected\r\n\r\nerror: build of '/nix/store/n8iaf4rn7i1w18d2yjk0b8j92v0284ji-is-formatted-0.1.0.drv' failed with exit code 1;\r\n\r\nlast 25 log lin
es:\r\n\r\n> Running phase: updateAutotoolsGnuConfigScriptsPhase\r\n\r\n> Running phase: configurePhase\r\n\r\n> Running phase: buildPhase\r\n\r\n> Compiling 15 files (.ex)\r\n\r\n> Gene
rated nix_phoenix_template app\r\n\r\n> Running phase: checkPhase\r\n\r\n> ERROR formatter | mix-fmt: failed to apply with options '[]': exit status 1\r\n\r\n>\r\n\r\n>\r\n\r\n> 15:57:04.
183 [error] beam/beam_load.c(150): Error loading module 'Elixir.Hex':\r\n\r\n> corrupt atom table\r\n\r\n>\r\n\r\n>\r\n\r\n> 15:57:04.229 [error] beam/beam_load.c(150): Error
loading module 'Elixir.Hex':\r\n\r\n> corrupt atom table\r\n\r\n>\r\n\r\n>\r\n\r\n>\r\n\r\n> 15:57:04.229 [error] beam/beam_load.c(150): Error
non-interactively, use 'mix local.hex --force*' [n] ** (Mix) Could not find an SCM for dependency :phoenix from NixPhoenixTemplate.MixProject\r\n\r\n>\r\n\r\n> Traversed 65 files\r\n\r\n>
emitted 55 files for processing\r\n\r\n> formatted 22 files (2 changed) in 687ms\r\n\r\n> Error: failed to finalise formatting: formatting failures detected\r\n\r\n> For full logs, run 'nix log
/nix/store/n8iaf4rn7i1w18d2yjk0b8j92v0284ji-is-formatted-0.1.0.drv'.\r\n\r\nerror: builder for '/nix/store/n8iaf4rn7i1w18d2yjk0b8j92v0284ji-is-formatted-0.1.0.drv' failed with exit code 1\r\n\r\n""",
repositories_000001.json
3664:  "website": "https://garnix.io/repo/baileyuTCD/elixir-blueprint",
pull_requests_000001.json
1195:  "body": "Uses the garnix cache to deploy prebuilt documentation to github pages",
```

Which is something I found particularly surprising as GitHub absolutely keep this data around somewhere on a per user basis as evidenced by the entry on the `apps` page used for integrations with third party services like Garnix:

Applications

📁 Installed GitHub Apps 🛠 Authorized GitHub Apps 🔑 Authorized OAuth Apps

GitHub Apps augment and extend your workflows on GitHub with commercial, open source, and homegrown tools.

 Fly.io Configure

 Garnix CI Configure

Investigating this menu led me to discover that there was, in fact, a list of "Authorized OAuth Apps", very clearly indicating that the supposed "Total Export of Account Data" does not contain all of the data that GitHub has on me, which, even being obvious as an end user leads me to believe that they have vastly more data on me than they are letting on, perhaps stored somewhere separately.

Conclusions

In conclusion, due to various concerns with GitHub, both as a platform/product and as a result of being owned by Microsoft, I had decided that now was as opportune of a time as any to investigate what data GitHub has on me, as unfortunately I have no choice but to rely on them both for open source contributions and for professional work.

In general the process for accessing my data was trivial, both avenues I attempted lead me back to the same tarball archive download, although the actual contents of said tarball appeared to lack data about me that GitHub very obviously has stored somewhere, leading me to extrapolate that the actual amount of data they store about me to be far more vast than just what they give out to end users.

1. <https://www.cnet.com/tech/tech-industry/microsoft-acquire-github-7-5-billion-stock-solidify-developer-ties/> - Accessed 19th December 2025 ↩
2. <https://ziglang.org/news/migrating-from-github-to-codeberg/> - Accessed 19th December 2025 ↩
3. <https://www.vox.com/recode/2019/10/9/20906605/github-ice-contract-immigration-ice-dan-friedman> - Accessed 19th December 2025 ↩
4. <https://github.com/actions/runner/issues/3792> - Accessed 19th December 2025 ↩
5. <https://www.businessinsider.com/github-ceo-developers-embrace-ai-or-get-out-2025-8> - Accessed 19th December 2025 ↩
6. <https://docs.github.com/en/actions/how-tos/secure-your-work/security-harden-deployments/oidc-in-cloud-providers> - Accessed 19th December 2025 ↩

7. <https://docs.github.com/en/get-started/archiving-your-github-personal-account-and-public-repositories/requesting-an-archive-of-your-personal-accounts-data> - Accessed 19th December 2025 ↩ ↩

8. DPO Response

Thank you for your email. You are receiving this because you have emailed dpo@github.com. While we do read the emails received to this inbox, we have prepared this automated response because we have found that most requests received to this inbox fall into one of a few categories and we want you to receive the information you need as quickly as possible.

Data Subject Requests (e.g. requests to access or delete your data). GitHub is a service that provides software developers an open source platform to build and collaborate. You can read more about us and our policies in the GitHub Terms of Service (<https://docs.github.com/en/site-policy/github-terms/github-terms-of-service>) and the GitHub Privacy Statement (<https://docs.github.com/en/site-policy/privacy-policies/github-privacy-statement>).

In order to process your access, edit, and deletion/erasure request, please follow these instructions outlined below. You can view, edit, and delete the personal data we store about you while signed into your account and viewing your profile settings:

- <https://github.com/settings/profile>
- <https://github.com/settings/billing>

To delete your personal data and account, please follow the instructions on the Deleting your Personal Account (<https://docs.github.com/account-and-profile/setting-up-and-managing-your-personal-account-on-github/managing-your-personal-account/deleting-your-personal-account>) page.

If you would like a copy of your account user data (such as repositories and Issues), please follow the instructions located on the Requesting an archive of your personal account's data (<https://docs.github.com/en/get-started/privacy-on-github/requesting-an-archive-of-your-personal-accounts-data>) page.

Enterprise Users. If you are an Enterprise User, please contact your company's IT team or appropriate person to request data deletion or access.

Authorized Agents. If you are an authorized agent making a request on behalf of another individual, please reply to this email with the following information: the name of the authorized agent, written proof of permission that the authorized agent may act on behalf of the user for whom this request is being made, and verification of the identity of the user for whom this request is being made.

If you have previously provided us with your business contact information, and would like for it to be deleted, please reply to this email and specify that, and we will assist.

Takedown Requests. If you are requesting the removal of information from an area of GitHub, please review and follow the GitHub Takedown Process (<https://docs.github.com/en/site-policy/content-removal-policies/guide-to-submitting-a-dmca-takedown-notice>).

Opt-out Requests. You have choices with respect to the data that we may have associated with your devices that have been collected and used for showing ads or sending marketing communications. Please follow the instructions located in our Privacy Statement to opt-out of cookies (<https://docs.github.com/en/site-policy/privacy-policies/github-privacy-statement#what-are-your-cookie-choices-and-controls>) and/or marketing communications (<https://docs.github.com/en/site-policy/privacy-policies/github-privacy-statement#communication-preferences>).

Whichever method you decide to use, remember to read the information available on the pages about the opt-out and how to make sure you stay opted-out in the future. Some opt-out tools are cookie based, so if you change computers or browsers or delete your cookies, we will no longer know you have opted-out, and you will need to opt-out again.

Do Not Sell Requests. GitHub does not sell personal data. You may use the Global Privacy Control (GPC) (<https://globalprivacycontrol.org/>) to communicate your privacy preferences. If GitHub detects the GPC signal from your device, GitHub will not share your data (we do not sell your data). To learn more, visit Global Privacy Control — Take Control Of Your Privacy (<https://globalprivacycontrol.org/>).

Thank you for contacting us.

Kind Regards,

GitHub DPO
dpo@github.com

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9. [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tar_\(computing\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tar_(computing)) - Accessed 19th Decemeber 2025 ↩

10. <https://garnix.io/> - Accessed 19th December 2025 ↩